

A Note on Compounds and Definite Articles

Richard S. Kayne
New York University

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In earlier work, I suggested the following conjecture, in particular for the case of arguments that look like full DPs:¹

(1) Arguments invariably raise at least once, in all languages.

The question now arises as to whether or not (1) could be taken to extend even to cases in which it seems that there is an argument that is a NP, but not a DP, as in English compounds and in various other types of incorporation cross-linguistically.

Of relevance is the fact that there are instances of D-stranding under noun-incorporation to verbs, as discussed in Baker (1996, 299, 313, 334, 413) for Mohawk and Southern Tiwa. Baker's examples suggest the possibility that all instances of N(P)-incorporation involve a stranded D, which will often be silent. If so, then N(P)-incorporation will fit into (1).²

Baker (1996, 307) points out the (partial) similarity between compounding of the English sort and incorporation of the sort just discussed. And in fact there is evidence from English compounding that leans in the direction of a silent D. I have in mind contrasts like the following:³

¹Cf. Kayne (2011, (6); 2022, (2)). The argument phrases that Cardinaletti (2001) takes to be in situ must have been moved, if this conjecture is correct, in which case we would interpret 'in situ' in the cases she discusses as 'in their canonical position'.

The idea that argument phrases must raise at least once recalls Moro's (1997, 139) proposal that "predicates apply only to variables at LF", a proposal that took the trace/copy theory of movement to be correct, whereas the text 'raise at least once' conjecture is neutral as to the correctness of that theory. A second difference has to do with Kayne's (1981) interpreting the locality difference between French object clitic movement and French *tout*-movement to reflect the fact that *tout*-movement is linked to a variable while clitic movement is not.

Perhaps obligatory raising reflects the language faculty's counterpart of a motion detector. Arguments, at least, are visible only if they move, or only as they move.

²Especially if NP is in general the true argument, which it will be if the DP-hypothesis is not correct; cf. Bruening (2020) and Chomsky et al. (2019, 248).

³Cf. the absence of a pre-prefix on Lubukusu adverbials discussed by Wasike and Diercks (2021), which might allow taking the prefixes on those adverbials to be noun class markers; cf. also:

i) That stream is very (*the) Hudson River-like.

ii) That bread looks like it's (*the) mold-free now.

Note that English compounding allows separation of noun from verb by a particle:

iii) You're an avid music downloader, aren't you?

with the pre-V position of *down* in (iii) recalling the obligatory pre-V position of the particle in Swedish participial passives as recently discussed by Lundquist (2014).

(2) They just love *(the) Hudson River.

(3) They're real (*the) Hudson River-lovers.

The fact that *the* is obligatory in (2) makes it plausible to take (3) to contain a silent counterpart of *the*, namely THE (capitals will indicate silence).

The presence of a silent THE might then be extended to non-proper-name compounds like:⁴

(4) They're real magazine-lovers.

thinking of:

(5) The magazine has long been an important part of American culture.

which suggests that silent THE in (4) would be generic-like,⁵ as is overt *the* in (5).

And/or the THE of (4) might be akin to the overt weak *the* of:

(6) They're in the hospital.

which is in fact silent in (6) in at least some British English.

Partially similar in having THE may well be:

(7) They would like to have a third child.

against the background of:

(8) They would like to have a child that would be the third one.

with (7) then to be analyzed in the direction of:

(9) ...have a BE THE third child

in which 'BE THE third' would be a reduced relative.

In approximately the same vein, we can note:

(10) That was a most important book.

(11) That was a book of the utmost importance.

with this pair suggesting that we take (10) to be as in:⁶

(12) ...a THE UT-most important book

If so, we can account for the well-known restriction seen in:

(13) *That was a finest book.

via the contrast between *utmost* and **ut-est*, i.e. between (11) and:

(14) *That was a book of the ut-est importance.

Nor would we now expect to have, in any way parallel to (10):

(15) *That was a least important book.

given the impossibility of:

(16) *That was a book of the utleast importance.

⁴Relevant here is Schwarz (2013), as well as Collins (2007).

⁵And/or like the definite article of French partitives, as in:

i) Nous achetons de la bière. ('we buy of the beer' = 'we're buying beer')

Cf. Kayne (1975, sect. 2.9).

⁶There might also be a silent TO, thinking of:

i) the leftmost door

ii) the door (the) most to the left

In addition, *ut-* may be closely related to *utter*, as in:

iii) an utter failure; utterly wrong

leading to the possibility of:

iv) ...a TO THE UTT-ER most important book

with this *-er* the same as that of *outer*.

In conclusion, the conjecture in (1) has considerable plausibility. In effect, there are plausibly no in situ arguments in the strict sense of the term, i.e. no arguments that remain in their external-merge position throughout the derivation, in any language.

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